



Microsoft 365 in VR (Courtesy: Microsoft)

thought leaders and industry majors have radically different views about it. At the WSJ Live Conference in October, Evan Spiegel, Founder of Snap Inc. argued that the future of computing is not the metaverse, and that most people would prefer augmented reality, which lets people harness computing power without forcing them to rely on a single screen. “The metaverse is ‘living inside of a computer.’ The last thing I want to do when I get home from work during a long day is live inside of a computer,” Spiegel says.

At the same event, Greg Joswiak, Senior Vice President of Worldwide Marketing at Apple Inc., is said to have commented that the metaverse is a word he would never use! And Phil Spencer, Head of Xbox at Microsoft, called the metaverse a “poorly built video game.”

In a recent interview with Bright, a Dutch media house, CEO Tim Cook explained why Apple is still hesitant to join the metaverse hype. He said, “I always think it’s important that people understand what something is. And I’m really not sure the average person can tell you what the metaverse is.”

He instead bets on AR becoming the next big trend in computing. From teaching to medicine, there are many fields that it will revolutionise,

and it is likely to be to the next generation what the internet is to us. “I think AR is a profound technology that will affect everything. Imagine suddenly being able to teach with AR and demonstrate things that way. Or medically, and so on. Like I said, we are really going to look back and think about how we once lived without AR,” he remarked.

Nokia, on the other hand, seems to have a positive prediction for the metaverse. As reported by *The Spokesman-Review*, Nokia’s Chief Strategy and Technology Officer Nishant Batra shared their belief that the mobile phone will be overtaken by a metaverse experience in the second half of the decade. “Widespread adoption of the technology from both corporations and consumers will be critical for it to really take off, and this will also depend on the availability of affordable, ergonomic wirelessly connected VR and AR devices,” he added.

In the meanwhile, Meta, the name that comes to mind as soon as you think about the metaverse, is in dire straits. The company’s market value has plummeted pathetically this year. With the steady drop in share prices, Mark Zuckerberg has already lost around 61% of his wealth since the start of 2022, according to the Bloomberg Bil-

lionaires Index. This has pulled him down from being the third richest person in the world to twenty-third.

In *Time to Get Fit—an Open Letter from Altimeter to Mark Zuckerberg* (and the Meta Board of Directors), Brad Gerstner, CEO of Altimeter Capital and Meta shareholder, wrote, “Meta has drifted into the land of excess—too many people, too many ideas, too little urgency. This lack of focus and fitness is obscured when growth is easy but deadly when growth slows and technology changes.” To get its mojo back, Gerstner says Meta needs to get fit and focused. He recommends that they reduce headcount expense by at least 20%; reduce annual capex by at least \$5 billion; and limit investment in metaverse/Reality Labs to no more than \$5 billion per year.

Yet, Zuckerberg is not ready to give up. After posting a dismal third-quarter earnings statement, he is said to have defended the company saying, “I get that a lot of people might disagree with this investment but from what I can tell, I think this is going to be a very important thing... It’s some of the most historic work we’re doing that people will look back at over decades. Those who are patient and invest with us will end up being rewarded.”

A McKinsey report predicts that the metaverse will add \$5 trillion to the value of the global economy by 2030. Thought leader Bernard Marr states in a Forbes report that, “There’s everything to play for, and 2023 is likely to be a key year for defining the direction it will take.”

The metaverse is likely to emerge as an effective marketing channel. Industries will warm up to the idea of using ‘digital twins’ to bring in operational efficiencies. VR and AR technologies are likely to improve. And all of these might give the metaverse a much-needed fillip. We will see you with more metaverse news and trends next year! **EFY**